10.3 Rockets and Guns

WORKSHEET

The question

STEP III 2017, Question 11

Read the question before you go on. It is in the STEP Support Programme's question database:

step.maths.org/questions/17-s3-q11

Hints

Try the question on your own first. If you get stuck, read the hints *one at a time*, and go back to the question after each one. Hints marked *Pause and try* are the key steps.

Ask yourself Before a gun fires, the truck moves at V. Afterwards the projectile's velocity is $V - v$ (that is, speed $v - V$ backwards). What is the projectile's velocity *relative to the truck before firing*?

STAGE 2 One at a time

Ask yourself Just before the rth gun fires, what is the mass of the truck with its remaining projectiles, and what is its speed? Write down conservation of momentum for the rth firing.

Pause and try Why does firing one at a time do worse here? When the first gun fires, it has to accelerate the truck *and* the $n - 1$ unfired projectiles, so it produces less of a speed increase than it would on the bare truck.

STAGE 3 The energy bill

Ask yourself Write down the change in kinetic energy at the rth firing. How can $(*)$ help you simplify the term involving $u_r^2 - u_{r-1}^2$?

Try this next

1 **The other convention.** Redo parts (i) and (ii) supposing each projectile leaves at speed v relative to the truck *after* firing. Show that now firing one at a time gives the larger final speed.

2 **A comet in a dust cloud.** Try STEP III 2009, Question 11 (step.maths.org/questions/09-s3-q11). It is a variable-mass problem like the rocket, but the comet gains mass instead of losing it. Look out for the speed it tends to.

3 **Two stages.** A rocket has exhaust speed v, empty mass M and fuel mass $9M$. Find its final speed. Now split it into two stages, each with empty mass $\frac{1}{2}M$ and fuel $4.5M$, the first stage being dropped when empty. Compare the final speeds.

4 **The inequality.** Prove that $\frac{x}{1+x} \le \ln(1+x) \le x$ for $x \ge 0$, by comparing $\frac{1}{1+s}$ with 1 and with $\frac{1}{1+x}$ on $[0, x]$.

Further reading

- **Daniel Kleppner & Robert Kolenkow, *An Introduction to Mechanics*** (Cambridge University Press), Chapter 4. Momentum, variable mass and the rocket equation.
- **George Sutton & Oscar Biblarz, *Rocket Propulsion Elements*** (Wiley). The standard engineering text; the opening chapters are readable after this section.
- **Hermann Oberth, *Ways to Spaceflight*** (NASA translation, free online). A pioneer's own account.

The full guided solution, and what the question leads to at university, is in Section 10.3:
https://beyondstep.keithmcnulty.org/ch10/rockets.html